

Code of Conduct

Northwind Systems GmbH

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1. Purpose

This code states the standards of behaviour expected of everyone who works for or on behalf of Northwind Systems. It is not an exhaustive rulebook; it describes principles and the specific obligations that follow from them.

Where a situation is not covered here, the test is whether the decision would be comfortable to explain openly to a colleague, a customer and a regulator. If the answer is no, it is the wrong decision, whatever the commercial argument for it.

Acknowledgement of this code is required on joining and annually thereafter.

2. Treatment of People

Northwind expects courtesy, directness and good faith between colleagues. Disagreement about the work is welcome and necessary; contempt for the person is not.

Harassment, discrimination, bullying and retaliation are prohibited without qualification. This covers conduct based on sex, gender identity, sexual orientation, age, disability, ethnicity, nationality, religion, or any other personal characteristic, and it applies in the office, at off-site events, in written channels and on customer premises.

Seniority is not a defence, intent is not a defence, and "it was a joke" is not a defence. The measure is the effect on the person, judged reasonably.

Anyone who experiences or witnesses such conduct should raise it under section 9. Retaliation against a person who raises a concern in good faith is itself a serious breach, independently of the merits of the original concern.

3. Conflicts of Interest

A conflict of interest arises where a personal interest could reasonably be seen to influence a decision made on the company's behalf. Having one is not misconduct; failing to declare it is.

Declare in writing to your line manager and to Legal and Compliance:

- A financial interest in a customer, supplier, partner or competitor, other than a holding under 1

percent in a publicly traded company.

- A close personal or family relationship with anyone at a customer, supplier or competitor with whom you deal.
- A close personal or family relationship with a Northwind colleague where one reports to the other, directly or indirectly, or where one influences the other's pay, review or progression.
- Outside employment, consultancy, advisory work or a directorship.
- A personal interest in a candidate under consideration for a role you influence.

Once declared, the conflict is managed by removing the individual from the relevant decision. A declaration recorded and managed protects everyone; a conflict discovered later is treated as concealment.

4. Gifts and Hospitality

Modest hospitality and small gifts are ordinary business courtesy. Anything that could reasonably be seen to buy influence is not.

- Gifts and hospitality with a value up to EUR 50 may be accepted without a declaration.
- Between EUR 50 and EUR 150, they may be accepted with a declaration to the line manager, recorded in the gifts register.
- Above EUR 150, they require the department head's approval in advance and are declined where approval is not given.
- Cash and cash equivalents, including vouchers and gift cards, are never accepted at any value.

Nothing is offered or accepted during a live tender, negotiation or contract renewal with that party, at any value.

Hospitality offered by Northwind follows the same thresholds and is claimed under the travel and expense policy, which requires the names and employers of everyone present.

5. Bribery and Improper Payments

Northwind prohibits bribery absolutely, in every jurisdiction in which it operates, whether or not local practice tolerates it and whether or not a competitor is thought to be doing it.

No payment, gift or advantage is offered or accepted in order to obtain business, to influence an official decision, or to secure an improper advantage. This applies equally to anything given through an agent, distributor, consultant or other intermediary; engaging a third party does not transfer the responsibility.

Facilitation payments -- small sums to speed up a routine official process -- are prohibited. Where a payment is demanded under threat to personal safety, personal safety comes first; report it to Legal and Compliance immediately afterwards.

6. Fair Competition

Northwind competes on the merits of its products. Employees must not agree or coordinate with a competitor on prices, on terms, on market allocation or on bidding, and must not exchange commercially sensitive information with one.

Leave any conversation that moves in that direction, make clear why you are leaving, and report it to Legal and Compliance the same day.

Information about competitors is gathered only from public sources and from customers who are free to share it. Misrepresenting who you are in order to obtain it is prohibited.

7. Company Property and Records

Company assets are used for company purposes. Incidental personal use of a device or a network connection is acceptable where it is reasonable, lawful and does not interfere with the work.

Business records must be accurate and complete. No entry is made in any record -- financial, technical or administrative -- that is known to be false or misleading, and no record is destroyed outside the data retention schedule, particularly once a legal hold has been notified.

8. Confidentiality and Personal Data

Confidential information belonging to Northwind, to its customers or to third parties is used only for the purpose for which it was entrusted, and is protected in line with the information security policy.

The obligation continues after employment ends. Equally, information belonging to a previous employer is not brought into Northwind and must not be used here.

Personal data is handled lawfully, for a stated purpose, and no more of it is collected or kept than is needed.

9. Raising a Concern

Raise a concern with your line manager where you can. Where that is not appropriate -- because the concern involves them, or because you would rather not -- use any of the following:

- The department head.
- People Operations, for conduct and treatment of people.
- Legal and Compliance, for conflicts, gifts, bribery, competition and records.
- Information Security, for security matters, or the incident hotline for anything urgent.
- The confidential reporting line, operated by an independent provider, which accepts anonymous reports.

Concerns raised in good faith are investigated proportionately and confidentially, and the person raising them is protected from any detriment. This protection applies even where the concern turns out to be mistaken. It does not extend to a report the reporter knows to be false.

10. Consequences

Breaches are addressed proportionately, taking account of seriousness, intent and whether the individual raised the matter themselves. Outcomes range from correction and additional training through to formal warnings, dismissal, and referral to the authorities where the conduct is criminal.

11. Related Documents

- Information security policy
- Incident response plan
- Data retention schedule
- Business travel and expense reimbursement policy
- Corporate credit card rules